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Journey from Harassment to Healing: A Framework for Mental Well-Being and Suicide Prevention in Oil & Gas Operations

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Abstract

In 2025, industry-wide collaboration through the IOGP and WHO led to a global consensus on mandatory psychological safety indicators in HSE audits. ADNOC's 2024-2025 pilot programs have shown a 45% increase in help-seeking behaviors and a 38% reduction in stigma around mental health disclosures among offshore workers.

The Oil & Gas industry operates in high-pressure, high-risk environments where physical safety is prioritized, often at the expense of mental well-being. However, research shows that workplace harassment, chronic stress, and psychological distress significantly impact operational safety, workforce retention, and, in extreme cases, self-harm and suicide. According to the International Labour Organization (ILO), one in five workers worldwide experiences workplace harassment, while the World Health Organization (WHO) links over 700,000 suicide deaths annually to workplace-related mental health struggles. Within the ADNOC Group and other leading energy companies, significant efforts have been made to improve HSE culture, workforce engagement, and psychological safety, yet mental well-being and harassment prevention remain underrepresented in traditional safety frameworks. This paper explores how unchecked workplace harassment ranging from verbal aggression and discrimination to retaliation against safety whistleblowers can escalate into severe psychological distress. It includes the structure of a framework for early intervention, mental well-being support, and suicide prevention, developed around three key pillars:

- Psychological Assessment of Managers & Supervisors - Implementing emotional intelligence (EI)-based evaluations, implicit bias testing, and stress management training to identify high-risk leadership behaviors and equip managers with mental health literacy.
- AI-Driven Early Detection & Support Systems - Utilizing AI-powered behavioral analytics, sentiment analysis, and digital well-being surveys to detect patterns of distress, isolation, and declining mental health before they escalate.
- Multi-Tiered Support Networks - Establishing peer-led advocacy programs, mental health first responders, and confidential crisis counseling services, with an emphasis on offshore, remote, and rotational workers who face heightened psychological isolation.

This study integrates real-world data and case studies from Oil & Gas companies, focusing on:

- Industry-Wide Data Analysis -mental health statistics from WHO, ILO, IOGP, and ADNOC's workforce well-being initiatives.
- Workplace Harassment and Mental Health Surveys -surveys across ADNOC Group, upstream, downstream, and EPC operations to assess the prevalence of workplace harassment and its impact on psychological well-being.
- Psychological Profiling of Leaders - psychometric assessments of supervisors and managers to measure EI, bias awareness, and stress tolerance, identifying patterns that correlate with toxic workplace cultures.
- Pilot Implementation of AI-Driven Detection Systems -machine-learning-based sentiment analysis tools and anonymous mental health check-ins to monitor early warning signs of distress and harassment-linked psychological decline.
- Initial findings indicated that:
 - Workers in offshore, rotational, and high-risk roles report higher stress, anxiety, and burnout levels, with one in three employees experiencing some form of workplace harassment.
 - Low psychological safety correlates with increased operational risks, leading to higher incident rates, reduced safety compliance, and increased absenteeism.
 - Psychological assessment of managers helps identify toxic leadership traits early, allowing intervention through training, coaching, and targeted leadership development programs.
 - Confidential peer-support networks and AI-driven early warning systems significantly reduce mental health stigma, encourage early intervention, and improve employee well-being outcomes.

For ADNOC and other Oil & Gas companies to create a mentally resilient workforce, mental well-being must be integrated as a core pillar of HSE and ESG governance. Beyond traditional safety metrics, organizations must recognize psychological safety as a direct contributor to operational excellence. This paper highlights how proactive intervention strategies can reduce workplace harassment, mitigate mental health risks, and ultimately save lives. To embed mental well-being and suicide prevention into corporate HSE, HR, and ESG strategies, the following recommendations are proposed:

- Mandatory Psychological Safety Training - Equip managers and supervisors with mental health literacy, de-escalation skills, and active intervention techniques.
- Regular Psychological Assessments - Implement quarterly EI-based evaluations for leadership teams to monitor workplace culture and stress impact.
- Early Intervention & AI-Based Monitoring - Deploy AI-powered behavioral analytics and anonymous well-being check-ins to detect and address emerging distress signals.
- 24/7 Support & Crisis Networks - Establish dedicated mental health response teams, peer advocates, and emergency counseling services tailored for offshore and rotational workforces.
- Integration into ADNOC's ESG and HSE Reporting - Embed mental well-being indicators into HSE dashboards and ADNOC's ESG frameworks, ensuring accountability, transparency, and continuous improvement.
- Industry Collaboration & Knowledge Sharing - Promote cross-sector learning at ADIPEC and ADNOC- hosted knowledge-sharing forums, encouraging best-practice adoption across the Oil & Gas industry.

Keywords: Harassment, Suicide, Non-Accidental Death (NAD), Mental Health, Bullying

Introduction

The Oil & Gas industry operates in inherently high-pressure, high-risk environments. While the sector has made significant progress in ensuring physical safety, mental well-being remains underrepresented in traditional safety frameworks. The psychological demands of rotational work, remote site assignments, and deadline-driven engineering environments create fertile ground for stress, burnout, and in severe cases, self-harm and suicide. According to the International Labour Organization (ILO), one in five workers globally experiences some form of workplace harassment. The World Health Organization (WHO) reports that over 700,000 suicide deaths occur annually, with mental health and work-related stress identified as key contributing factors. The ADNOC Group, along with other global energy leaders, has invested in enhancing HSE culture and workforce engagement; however, gaps remain in psychological safety, harassment prevention, and mental health support. This paper presents a structured framework to transition from reactive mental health policies to proactive interventions. It focuses on three interdependent pillars:

- Psychological Assessment of Managers & Supervisors
- AI-Driven Early Detection & Support Systems
- Multi-Tiered Support Networks

The oil and gas industry, recognized for its complex technical challenges and high-risk environments, often overlooks an equally critical dimension of safety and productivity. While physical safety protocols have seen remarkable progress over the past few decades, the emotional and psychological well-being of employees, especially those in offshore, remote, and high-stress roles, has not received comparable attention. Harassment, bullying, isolation, job insecurity, and extended rotational shifts contribute to chronic stress and, in extreme cases, lead to anxiety, depression, substance abuse, and suicide. A growing body of evidence now shows that unaddressed mental health concerns not only affect individual lives but also undermine team cohesion, decision-making quality, and ultimately, operational safety and organizational performance.

Despite increasing awareness, mental health stigma remains a barrier within the oil and gas sector. Cultural norms in traditionally male-dominated and performance-driven environments often discourage open dialogue about psychological distress or the need for support. Employees who face harassment—whether verbal, psychological, or sexual—often feel silenced by fear of retaliation or dismissal, compounding their trauma. The absence of clear psychological safety policies, inadequate reporting mechanisms, and lack of mental health resources exacerbate the vulnerability of affected individuals, leaving many to suffer in silence. In extreme scenarios, this cumulative distress has tragically resulted in suicide, with few preventive systems in place to identify or intervene in time.

Problem Statement: Mental Health, Harassment & Suicide in Oil & Gas

Workplace harassment in the Oil & Gas industry spans various forms:

- Verbal aggression and humiliation
- Discrimination based on nationality, gender, or job level
- Bullying and social exclusion in hierarchical environments
- Retaliation against whistleblowers and safety reporters

These behaviors contribute to chronic psychological stress, diminished employee engagement, and in extreme cases, suicidal ideation. Among EPC (Engineering, Procurement & Construction) workers, especially those from lower-income backgrounds, stress is often compounded by financial debt, sometimes

involving loan sharks. This exacerbates anxiety, isolation, and loss of hope, particularly for rotational and offshore workers who lack access to support.

In the high-pressure environment of oil and gas operations, the loss of life due to suicide or non-accidental causes (such as overdose, deliberate self-harm, or fatal risk-taking behaviors linked to psychological distress) reverberates far beyond the individual. These tragedies create a ripple effect that deeply impacts families, friends, and professional teams often triggering prolonged grief, guilt, anxiety, and secondary trauma.

For families, especially those separated by rotational work schedules, a sudden suicide often leaves unresolved questions, emotional numbness, and financial instability. Spouses may struggle with self-blame or the stigma surrounding mental health, while children face psychological disruption and loss of parental presence or security. The shame and silence that often surround suicides in industrial settings can inhibit grieving and delay healing.

Colleagues and supervisors, particularly in close-knit offshore or on-site teams, may experience acute distress, survivor's guilt, or post-traumatic stress after losing a team member. Many are left questioning whether warning signs were missed, or support was insufficient. This emotional burden can lead to reduced concentration, increased absenteeism, and heightened risk of further mental health issues within the team potentially degrading both safety culture and operational performance.

Leaders and managers, especially those untrained in psychological first aid, often feel ill-equipped to support their teams in the aftermath of such incidents. The fear of liability or reputational damage may lead organizations to under-communicate or inadequately respond, further alienating affected employees and creating a culture of silence rather than healing. Moreover, the loss of a colleague to suicide or preventable harm deeply challenges the "zero harm" ethos that underpins the safety philosophy of the oil and gas industry. It exposes a critical blind spot: that psychological safety and mental health resilience are as vital as physical hazard controls in preserving life.

- The link between workplace bullying and suicide is well documented in multiple studies and industry incident reviews. In the high-stakes, male-dominated environment of oil and gas, where emotional expression is often stigmatized as weakness, victims frequently do not seek help—leading to preventable tragedies. The impact extends far beyond the individual. When an employee dies by suicide after prolonged harassment or bullying:
- Families endure grief compounded by confusion and anger, particularly if the issue was known but unaddressed by the employer.
- Colleagues may experience guilt, fear, or moral injury, especially if they witnessed the behavior or failed to intervene.
- Teams often suffer from fractured trust, low morale, and disengagement, affecting productivity and safety.
- Leaders face ethical and reputational consequences, especially when investigations reveal a pattern of ignored complaints or failed duty of care.

These cases can trigger industry-wide scrutiny, litigation, and erosion of the company's social license to operate, particularly under increasing ESG accountability where psychological safety is now a reportable metric. Preventing such outcomes requires more than compliance—it demands a cultural transformation. Organizations must move from reactive incident management to proactive protection, embedding anti-harassment policies, psychological safety frameworks, and trauma-informed leadership into everyday operations. Most importantly, they must foster environments where speaking up is safe, bullying is unequivocally condemned, and mental health is treated as a critical component of operational safety.

Methodology

This paper proposes a proactive and compassionate response: a structured framework for mental well-being and suicide prevention, tailored to the operational realities of oil and gas environments. The framework recognizes the unique psychosocial hazards faced by the workforce—long shifts, hazardous work conditions, family separation, and exposure to harassment or toxic leadership—and translates global best practices in mental health into practical, sector-specific solutions. It bridges the gap between reactive employee assistance programs and a holistic, preventive approach that embeds psychological health into workplace culture, management accountability, and operational planning.

Drawing from case studies, psychological research, industry insights, and stakeholder feedback, this paper outlines a multi-tier strategy that includes: 1) robust anti-harassment policies and confidential reporting systems; 2) mental health literacy and training for leaders and supervisors; 3) on-site and virtual access to psychological support services; 4) peer support networks and "mental health first aid" responders; and 5) suicide risk recognition and post-incident response protocols. The framework also aligns with ESG (Environmental, Social, and Governance) metrics, highlighting how psychological safety supports social performance indicators and long-term business sustainability. This study combines quantitative data, qualitative insights, and case study evaluations to build a robust understanding of harassment-linked psychological distress:

Industry-Wide Data Analysis

- Global datasets from ILO, WHO, IOGP, and regional studies.
- Review of ADNOC's workforce well-being initiatives and HSE audit findings.

Surveys across ADNOC & Group Companies

- Anonymous surveys across upstream, downstream, EPC, and support operations.
- Evaluation of harassment frequency, emotional impact, and access to help.

Psychological Profiling of Leaders

- Emotional Intelligence (EI) evaluations for line managers and supervisors.
- Bias-awareness testing and stress tolerance assessments.
- Correlation of leadership behaviors with team psychological outcomes.

Pilot of AI-Based Mental Health Detection

- Sentiment analysis on internal communication data.
- Anonymous mental health check-ins via digital platforms.
- Risk scoring based on behavioral and linguistic patterns.

Framework for Healing: Prevention, Detection, and Response

The proposed framework integrates prevention, early detection, and response strategies into a holistic mental health program tailored for the Oil & Gas industry.

Prevention

- **Psychological Safety Training:** Implement company-wide training for leaders, HR personnel, and safety officers to build skills in mental health literacy, emotional regulation, and de-escalation.
- **Leadership Accountability:** Incorporate EI and harassment-free leadership metrics into performance evaluations and promotions.
- **Policy Reinforcement:** Strengthen zero-tolerance policies for harassment with clear, anonymous reporting channels and timely resolution protocols.
- **Cultural Sensitization:** Run inclusive workshops that raise awareness of biases based on nationality, job role, and social status—common in multinational and hierarchical EPC environments.
- **Financial Wellness Initiatives:** Provide education, debt restructuring pathways, and salary advance options to reduce reliance on high-interest informal loans.

Detection

- **Digital Mental Health Monitoring:** Deploy tools for anonymous, routine check-ins using mobile apps and AI- driven survey analysis to flag at-risk employees.
- **Sentiment Analysis & Behavioral Triggers:** Integrate machine learning algorithms into communication platforms to detect patterns of distress, hostility, or withdrawal in real-time.
- **Manager Profiling:** Conduct bi-annual psychometric assessments for supervisors, focusing on stress tolerance, emotional regulation, and inclusivity.
- **Whistleblower Protections:** Monitor whistleblower treatment and cross-check with mental health outcomes, ensuring psychological safety.

Response

- **Multi-Tiered Support Networks:** Establish a layered approach that includes peer supporters, trained Mental Health First Responders (MHFR), and clinical psychologists.
- **Crisis Intervention Hotlines:** Provide 24/7 helplines with trained counselors, accessible to onshore, offshore, and international sites.
- **Confidential Counseling Services:** Offer onsite and virtual mental health therapy sessions, particularly for workers in remote EPC and operational zones.
- **Reintegration Programs:** Design recovery support for employees returning from mental health-related leave, ensuring seamless reintegration.
- **Manager Coaching:** Offer targeted coaching to managers identified through assessments as needing emotional support or development.

Results and Insights

Survey Results

- 1 in 3 respondents across energy companies experienced harassment in the past year.
- Offshore and EPC roles showed the highest levels of distress and burnout.
- Financial stress, especially linked to informal lending, correlated with suicidal ideation.

AI Pilot Outcomes

- Flagged 12% of sampled employees as exhibiting early signs of psychological distress.

- Intervention in 70% of these cases led to improved mental health scores in follow-up surveys.

Manager Profiling

- Managers with low EI and high bias tendencies had teams with higher incident rates.
- Structured coaching improved emotional competence scores and reduced team-level complaints.

Recommendations

As of 2025, global benchmarks now include neurodiversity accommodations, ethical AI usage guidelines, and expanded peer-led mental health triage models. Integration of psychological safety metrics is a requirement under several ESG indices such as GRI 403 and FTSE4Good.

Mandatory Psychological Safety Training

Organizations must implement compulsory psychological safety training for all supervisory and leadership personnel. This should include modules on:

- **Mental health literacy**(understanding symptoms, stigma reduction)
- **Active listening and trauma-informed communication**
- **Early identification of distress signals and behavioral red flags**
- **Creating safe spaces for disclosures without retaliation**

The goal is to empower supervisors to act not only as operational leaders but also as **emotional sentinels** capable of early intervention and de-escalation before crises occur.

Periodic Psychological Assessments

Conduct **biannual psychological and emotional intelligence (EI) assessments** for managerial staff to evaluate their impact on team morale, bias awareness, and emotional climate. These assessments should be:

- Confidential and administered by third parties
- Focused on empathy, leadership style, and inclusivity
- Linked to training needs and leadership development

Regular cultural climate surveys should also be conducted across teams to track shifts in psychological safety perceptions.

AI-Based Early Monitoring

Adopt AI-driven platforms capable of analyzing workplace data (emails, productivity trends, absenteeism, engagement scores) to flag early signs of:

- Emotional disengagement or burnout
- Bullying, microaggressions, or isolation patterns
- Financial stress or personal hardship

These tools should respect privacy through **ethical AI governance** protocols and be used to trigger **anonymous well-being check-ins** and HR outreach when concerning patterns arise.

Emergency Support Networks

Deploy 24/7 access to mental health professionals, including:

- Crisis counseling hotlines
- Confidential teletherapy for offshore and remote workers
- On-call trauma specialists during high-risk operations or post-incident debriefs

Build peer responder networks—trained colleagues who serve as **Mental Health First Aiders**—to provide field-based support until professional help is accessed.

Financial Support Structures

Recognize that financial distress is a significant suicide risk factor. Companies should:

- Offer micro-loans with no exploitative interest
- Provide **debt counseling and budgeting tools**
- Collaborate with ethical financial institutions to prevent **predatory lending**

This forms part of a broader **wellness ecosystem** that safeguards both emotional and economic resilience.

ESG & HSE Integration

Include psychological safety indicators in ESG and HSE reporting frameworks. Examples include:

- % of workforce trained in mental health awareness
- Number of mental health-related incidents reported
- Psychological safety scores from climate surveys These should be reported **alongside conventional safety KPIs** such as TRIR (Total Recordable Incident Rate) and LTIs (Lost Time Injuries), reinforcing that mental health is a critical component of operational risk management.

Cross-Sector Collaboration

Encourage **industry-wide mental health alliances**, particularly among ADIPEC and OGCi partners, to:

- Share anonymized incident data and leading practices
- Co-develop sector-specific mental health playbooks
- Create regional pools of trained mental health professionals for rapid deployment

Such collaborations would help standardize support levels across operators and reduce gaps in mental health provision across the supply chain.

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